

ADAPTED PAYLOADS:

USER TESTING RESULTS & INSIGHTS



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INTRODUCTION

AdAdapted's Payload as a Service technology (PaaS) is a proven tool for enhancing the ad viewing experience, increasing ad unit engagement, and accelerating cart transfers. When a Payload tag is attached to an ad unit, audiences can seamlessly add products to their cart without interrupting their current online experience.

In April 2024, the engineering team at AdAdapted conducted moderated user interviews with internal employees to test their understanding of the PaaS configuration site, called Payloads. Each participant had little knowledge of PaaS before the interview, and their mission was to assume the role of a marketing manager who was using the site to set up payload tags for the

EXPLORE FINDINGS FROM OUR INTERVIEWS OF 10 ADADAPTED EMPLOYEES TO PROVIDE INSIGHT INTO HOW WE CAN BUILD GREATER USABILITY INTO THE PAYLOADS SITE AND ENSURE THAT NEW USERS FEEL CONFIDENT USING IT.

first time. The moderator asked participants to complete a series of tasks using data provided in a ticket, and also assessed their sentiments throughout the process. The key focus was to observe and compare users' ease in setting up payloads using both the Simple and Advanced creation methods.

The following insights detail the team's findings from this study.

KEY INSIGHTS

01

SIMPLE CREATION RESULTS FROM TASK 1

While using Simple Creation to set up Payloads was relatively straightforward for our interviewees, they had trouble in a few important areas. Simple Creation can be improved to better suit new users.

02

ADVANCED CREATION RESULTS FROM TASK 2

Interview participants had more trouble setting up Payloads using Advanced Creation. While this was expected, our participants' struggles were consistent and occurred in a few specific areas, leading us to solid bases for improvements.

03

KEY FINDINGS COMBINING OUR RESULTS

Our participants were able to learn a lot about Payloads through these interviews. Advanced Creation proved to be more difficult than Simple Creation, but Simple Creation can be a valuable tool for guidance and onboarding.

04

ADDITIONAL UI IMPROVEMENTS

Because our interviews were semi-structured, our interviewees were curious and explored pain points outside of our original scope. View additional improvements based on evidence from this study.

01

SIMPLE CREATION RESULTS FROM TASK 1

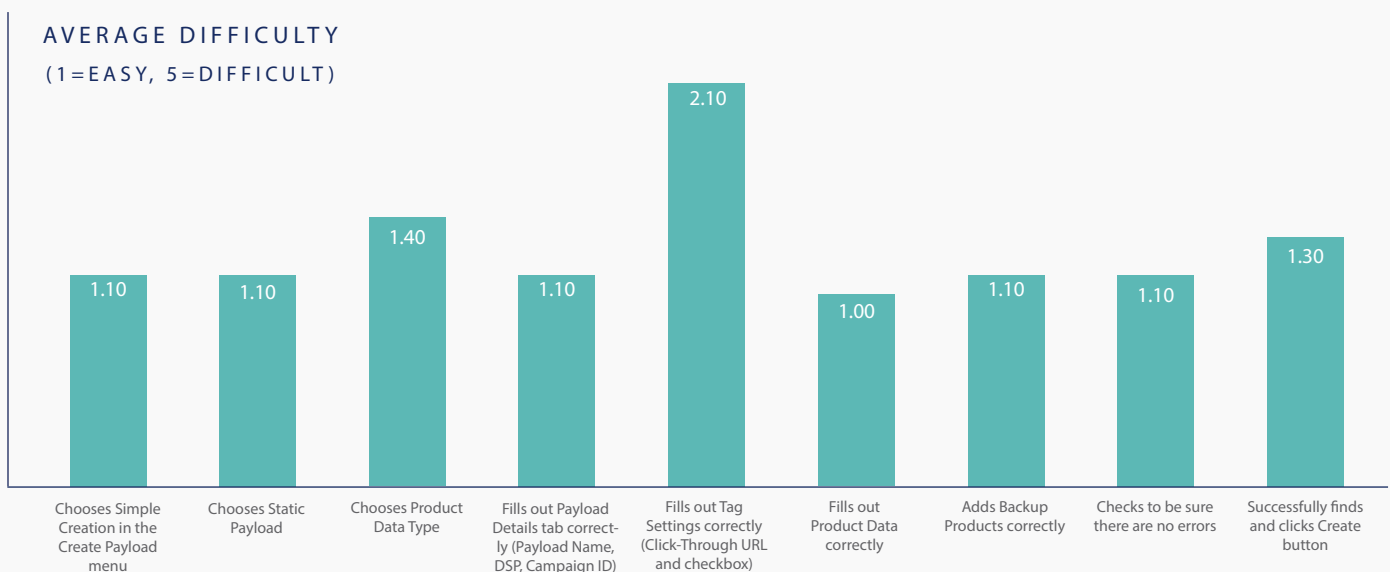
In user testing, we sought to determine the success with which new users would learn how to set up Payloads using Simple Creation. While using Simple Creation to set up Payloads was relatively straightforward for our interviewees, they had trouble in a few important areas.

Our participants completed the first part of Simple Creation -- Payload Details -- with ease. They expressed that it was straightforward, and there was “no loss of confidence” when the information given to them was consistent with the fields provided in the interface.

The next step -- Tag Settings -- revealed some pain points. Many participants had trouble determining whether to select the checkbox for allowing a click-through on initial click of the ad unit. Although a tool tip with guidance was provided, most participants did not take the time to read it, or they read it but did not understand it, or they ignored it altogether.

The next step -- Product Data -- was generally completed more slowly than other steps, but completed successfully by most participants. Participants expressed satisfaction that it was easy to follow the steps and that “it was laid

TASK DIFFICULTY - SIMPLE CREATION



out well so that it was easy to figure out which items went where.” Many were also able to articulate what it meant to have backups for a main product in case the main product was out of stock.

We observed a significant obstacle at the end of the form as participants had trouble finding the “Create” button. They expected it to be positioned alongside the “Previous” and “Next” buttons below the form rather than in the top right corner of the page.

Overall, participants felt fairly confident that they set up their Payload correctly using Simple Creation, citing an average of 4.05 on a confidence scale of 1-5 (with 1 being least confident, and 5 being most confident).

The diagram below outlines our observations and the improvements we are making based on our participants’ performance in completing this first task.

9 OUT OF 10

INTERVIEW PARTICIPANTS WERE CONFIDENT THAT THEY SET UP THE PAYLOAD CORRECTLY USING SIMPLE CREATION. THESE NINE RATED THEIR CONFIDENCE AS A 4 OR HIGHER.

OBSERVATIONS FROM TASK 1 - SIMPLE CREATION & RESULTING UI IMPROVEMENTS

OBSERVATION

Users felt unsure about the correct Click-Through URL setting. The provided explanation was often overlooked.

At the end of Simple Creation, users expected the ‘Create’ button to be positioned below form fields rather than in the upper right corner of their screen.

IMPROVEMENT

Condense and expose the explanation so that users clearly understand what will happen if they check/uncheck the Click-Through URL setting. (see 1.2)

Move the ‘Create’ button where it will be more intuitively clicked, closer to the ‘Next’ and ‘Previous’ buttons in the Simple Creation wizard. (see 1.1)

1.1

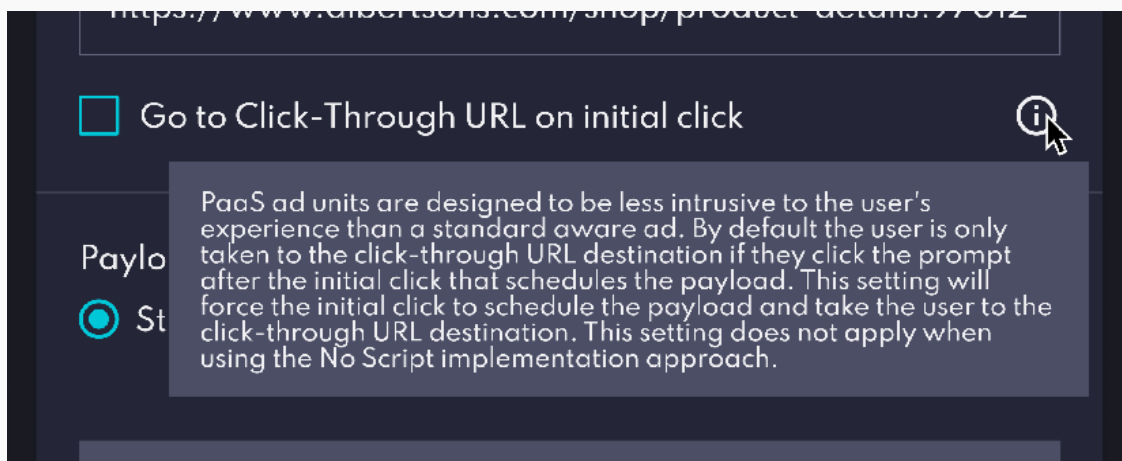
HELPER TEXT FOR CLICK-THRU URL SETTING

To guide users towards choosing the correct option for the click-thru URL behavior on their Payload ad unit, we made two key changes:

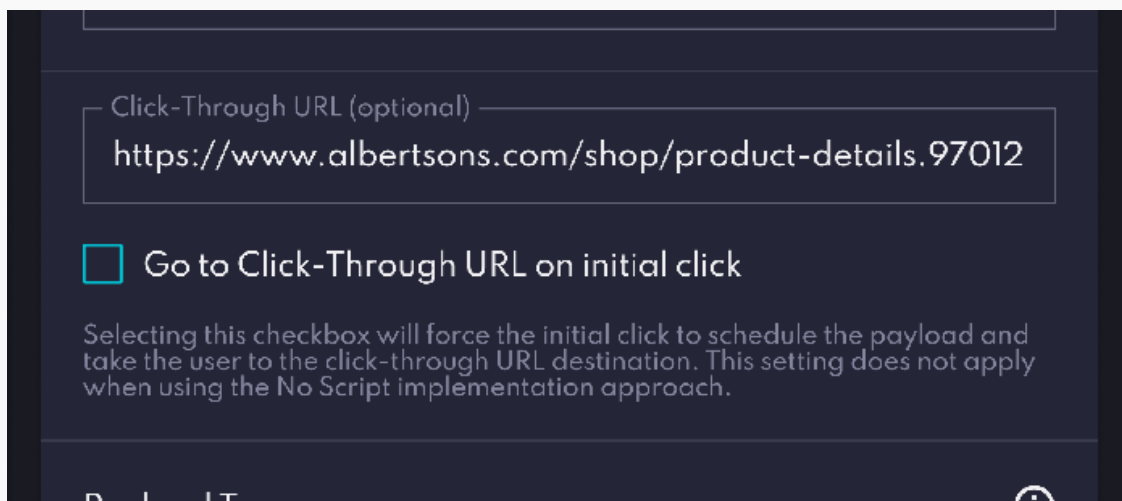
1. We edited the copy for conciseness and clarity using the context of the user's action (ie. what specifically will happen if the checkbox is clicked).
2. We made the text directly visible within the form instead of hiding it inside of a tool tip.

With these changes, usability is improved according to a UX heuristic called Parkinson's Law, which states that reducing the actual duration to complete a task from the expected duration will improve the overall user experience (lawsofux.com). We've prevented this task inflation by exposing critical information within the users' line of sight.

BEFORE



AFTER



1.2 SIMPLE MODE CREATE BUTTON POSITIONING

Participants consistently expressed frustration at the end of the Simple Creation form. After clicking 'Next' to proceed through the form, it was overwhelmingly expected that the Create button would be in a similar position below the form. To alleviate this brief but significant frustration, we've moved the Create button from the top right corner of the page down to below the form, next to the other navigation buttons.

This small change improves usability greatly according to Fitts's Law, which states that the time to acquire a target is a function of the distance to the target (lawsofux.com). In other words, the distance between a user's attention area and the task-related button should be kept as short as possible, which we've accomplished by moving the button closer to the end of the form.

BEFORE

The screenshot shows a dark-themed interface titled 'Create Payload'. At the top left is a '< Exit' button. At the top right is a green checkmark icon and a purple 'Create' button. Below the title are three tabs: 'Payload Details', 'Tag Settings', and 'Product Data' (which is selected and underlined). The form contains two input fields: 'Property Name' with the value 'MainProduct' and 'UPC/Product Code' with the value '01234567890'. Below these is a blue button with a plus icon and the text '+ Add Backup Item'. At the bottom center is a grey button with a left arrow and the text '← Previous Tab'.

AFTER

The screenshot shows the same 'Create Payload' form as before, but with the 'Create' button moved to the bottom right corner. The top right now only contains the green checkmark icon. The bottom of the form now includes a grey button with a left arrow, a grey button with a right arrow, the green checkmark icon, and the purple 'Create' button.

02

ADVANCED CREATION RESULTS FROM TASK 2

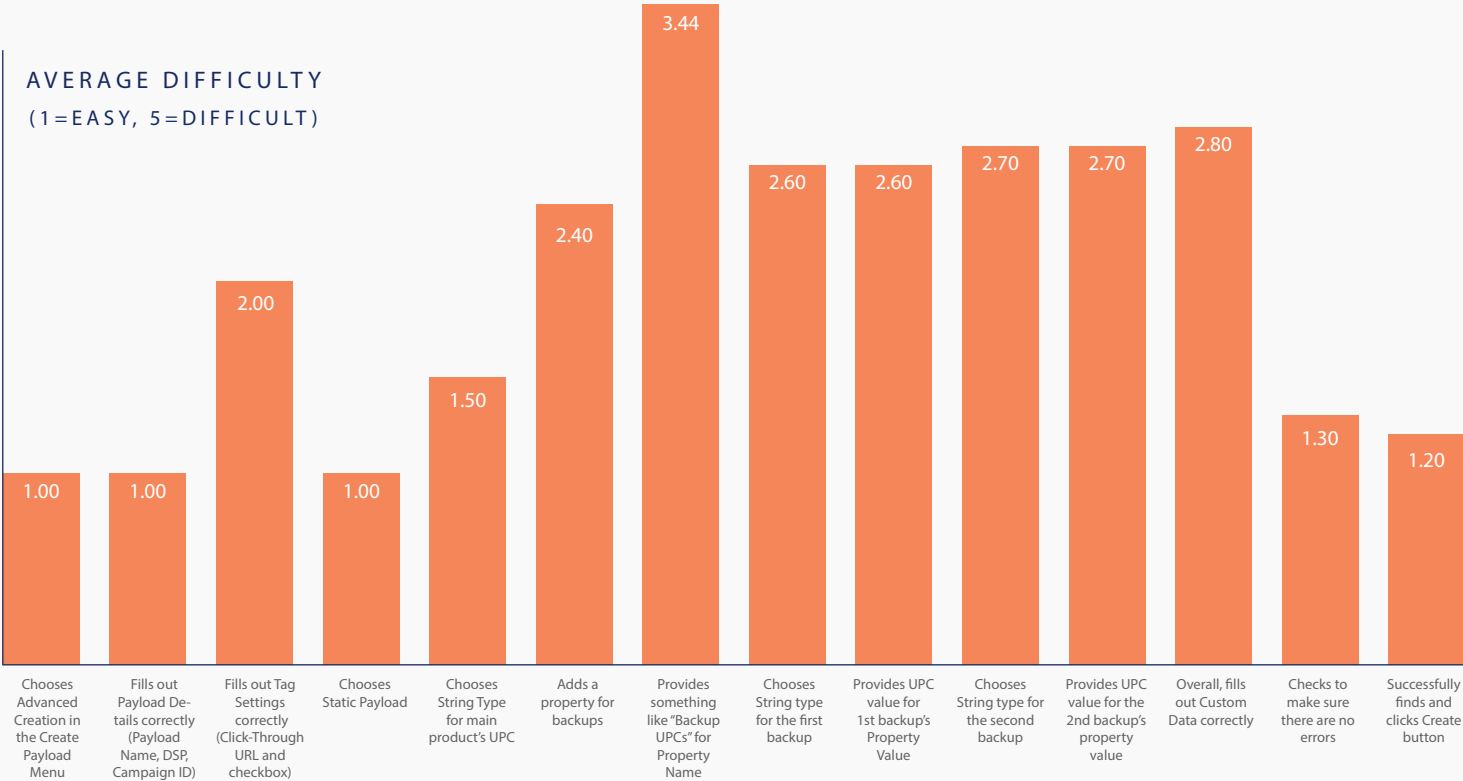
The second part of this study was to determine the ease with which new users could set up payloads using Advanced Creation. As expected, our participants had more trouble using Advanced Creation than they had using Simple Creation. However, their struggles were consistent and occurred in a few specific areas, leading us to solid bases for improvements.

In the first part of the creation process, users completed Payload Details with ease, as those inputs were familiar from the previous

task. Participants experienced some difficulty completing Tag Settings correctly, but with more ease than before. Some users still skipped over the guiding tool tip for the Click-Thru URL setting, but others took more care in understanding the correct input.

We hoped that completing Simple Creation first would contribute to a greater understanding of Advanced Mode’s Custom Data section, but it became clear that we did not provide sufficient guidance. On a scale of 1-5, with 1 being the

TASK DIFFICULTY - ADVANCED CREATION



least difficult and 5 being the most, the average difficulty for the Custom Data section was 2.59, compared to an average rating of 1.25 for all other sections.

In Custom Data, participants had trouble understanding Data Types. The default String input was often used, but participants expressed confusion for why they might switch to a different one. This led us to create a Data Type Dictionary for users to reference. Participants also struggled to provide valid Property Names for backup products. To eliminate that common error, we can restrict the user from creating a Payload if there are duplicate Property Names.

Overall, participants felt much less confident that they set up their Payload correctly using Advanced Creation, citing an average of 2.5 on a confidence scale of 1-5 (with 1 being least confident, and 5 being most confident).

The diagram below outlines our observations and the improvements we are making based on our participants' performance in completing this second task.

3 OUT OF 10

INTERVIEW PARTICIPANTS WERE CONFIDENT THAT THEY SET UP THE PAYLOAD CORRECTLY USING ADVANCED CREATION. SEVEN PARTICIPANTS RATED THEIR CONFIDENCE AS A 2.75 OR LOWER.

OBSERVATIONS FROM TASK 2 - ADVANCED CREATION & RESULTING UI IMPROVEMENTS

OBSERVATION

Users had trouble understanding the Data Types in Advanced Creation, including how the JSON could be built in many different ways and still produce a similar result.



IMPROVEMENT

Add a dictionary in the header of the Custom Data section to explain the data types. Include what property names/values might be used along with their corresponding data type. (Ex. Quantity might be a Number type) (see 2.1)

Most users ran into problems because they used the same Property Name multiple times, which ended up altering the JSON structure unintentionally. There was no indicator to inform users of this situation.



Along with a description of the JSON in a panel header, add validation for duplicate property names. The validation should appear in the page header as well as indicated on the affected fields. (see 2.2)

2.1 DATA TYPE DICTIONARY FOR CUSTOM DATA SETTINGS

Although users' 'Type' inputs were generally acceptable, their confidence may have increased had they known more about data types. To provide more information, we've added a Data Type dictionary to explain each type in the context of JSON structure as well as common Property Names and Property Values that can be used in the Custom Data form.

Data Type Dictionary			
Data Type	Definition	Common Uses	Examples
STRING	A continuous sequence of characters, enclosed in double quotes.	Product Names, Backup Names, Barcodes/UPCs	"Oranges" "01234567890"
NUMBER	Values that are integers or decimals. Cannot contain letters and are not enclosed in any special characters.	Quantities, Amounts	2 14.5
BOOLEAN	Values that are true or false.	Specify whether to check for backups or not	true false
OBJECT	Values that contain additional/nested key-value pairs.	Grouping related data into a single object	{ "Name" : "Oranges" "Qty" : 2 }
ARRAY	An ordered list of mixed value types that include string, number, or boolean.	Place all backup item barcodes/UPCs in a list	[0 : "0123456789" 1 : "6023456789"]

Tip: For Property Names, use unique labels. Property Names consist like "PROPERTY" and are always accompanied by Property Values, separated by a colon. Refer to this dictionary for Property Values.

Close

2.2 IN-FIELD VALIDATION FOR CUSTOM DATA SETTINGS

A prominent pain point in our Advanced Creation tests was providing valid inputs for the Custom Data form which builds the Payload's JSON structure. In the process, users tended to provide the same Property Name for backups, which is not supported. To prevent this error, we've done the following:

1. We've added indicators within each form field to communicate if inputs are valid right away
2. We've added validation to notify when any Property Name inputs are reused at any time

These changes increase usability according to the Goal-Gradient Effect (lawsofux.com), because providing clear indicators of success boost users' confidence and motivates them to continue.

The screenshot shows the Custom Data form with three rows of input fields. Each row has a 'Type' dropdown, a 'Property Name' field, and a 'Property Value' field. The first two rows have 'productBarcode' as the Property Name and a valid value. The third row has 'productBarcode' as the Property Name and an empty 'Property Value' field. Red exclamation marks are visible next to the 'productBarcode' inputs in the first two rows. A warning message is displayed at the bottom: 'The following items require attention prior to saving the payload: One or more Property Name inputs is repeated. All property names must be unique.' The 'Save' button is highlighted in purple.

03

KEY FINDINGS COMBINING TASKS 1 & 2

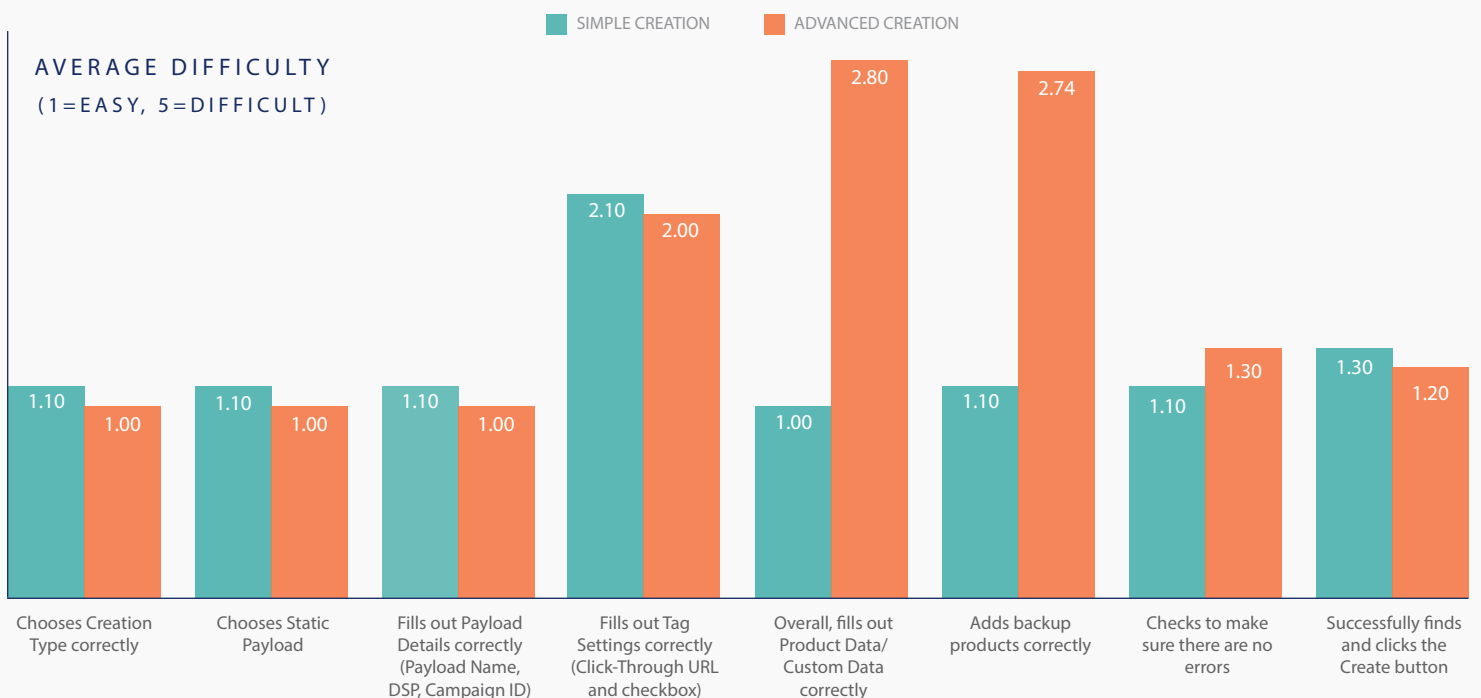
The majority of our interview participants preferred using Simple Creation over Advanced Creation, citing that it was more intuitive and “the less options there are, the better.” This sentiment is reflected in our data. The chart below illustrates the significant difficulty of completing the Custom Data section in Advanced Creation.

However, there is a general consensus that “whichever creation method was learned first could likely be the one that the user will be more inclined to use moving forward.” The chart below also suggests that some steps in the setup

process became easier once they were completed a second time. Further research may be conducted to assess the learning curve for new users.

A couple of our participants preferred Advanced Creation instead. They expressed that they “want to see everything at once instead of [stepping through a widget] because it is faster.” These sentiments confirm that both modes will be useful for our future clients, and both have the potential to be equally user-friendly.

TASK DIFFICULTY - COMBINED



04

ADDITIONAL UI IMPROVEMENTS

Because our interviews were semi-structured, our interviewees were curious and explored pain points outside of our original scope.

The diagram below outlines our observations and the additional improvements we are making based on our participants' feedback throughout all areas of the study.

ADDITIONAL OBSERVATIONS

& Resulting UI Improvements

OBSERVATION

After entering the payload edit screen, many users were drawn to examine the status pill, but it wasn't clear what the Inactive status meant.

Users had trouble finding the options available in the Actions menu, including Implementation Code, Live Charts, and Pause/Activate settings.

Many users looked to the General Info section or JSON code to find Implementation.

IMPROVEMENT

Add a message or tool tip to clarify statuses and what they mean for deliveries/impressions. Perhaps also add a confirmation modal once the payload is created to explain its status/lifecycle. (see 4.1)

Expose Implementation Code, Live Charts, and panel view options in the page header, outside of the Actions menu. The Actions menu should contain only actions to be applied to the Payload. (see 4.2)

Add a header to the JSON panel to describe the code as the structure of the payload that will be sent during the pickup process. (see 4.3)

4.1

ADD GUIDANCE TO CLARIFY PAYLOAD STATUS INDICATORS

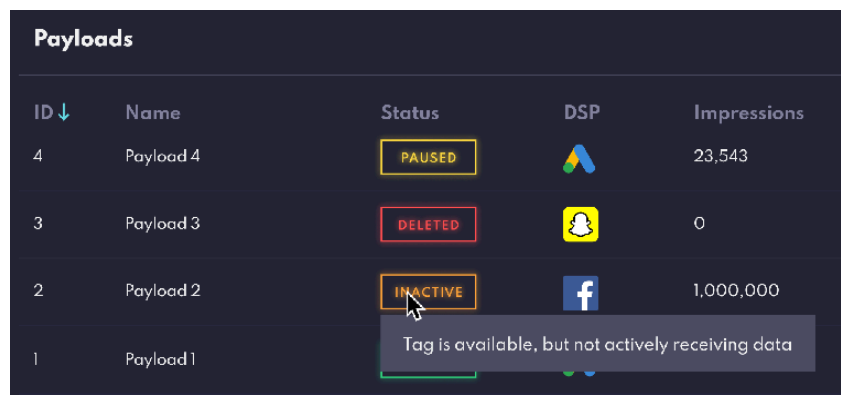
Most interview participants were drawn to viewing the General Info section of the post-creation screen immediately after creating their Payloads, regardless of which creation method they were using. It was important that they checked the status of the Payload in order to verify that their setup was successful and the Payload would work as expected.

Users looked to the 'Inactive' status pill first, which seemed to indicate to them that something was wrong. However, the status only indicates that the payload is not currently receiving data. A note to communicate that

'Inactive' still means that the Payload is set up successfully would have avoided confusion.

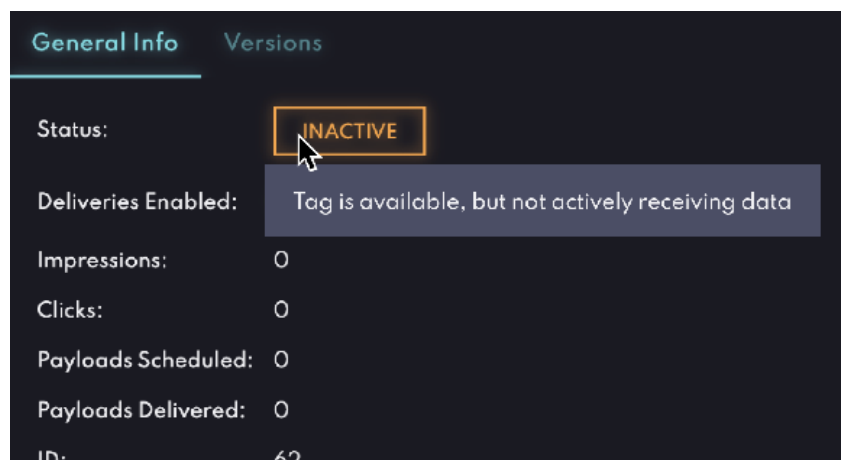
Another participant expected more of a confirmation that their settings were saved, and would have liked to see the Implementation Code given to them right away. Greater attention to the design of the user flow from setup completion to tag implementation is needed.

To remedy these issues, we've added explanations that appear when users hover over each Status pill:



ID ↓	Name	Status	DSP	Impressions
4	Payload 4	PAUSED		23,543
3	Payload 3	DELETED		0
2	Payload 2	INACTIVE		1,000,000
1	Payload 1			

Tag is available, but not actively receiving data



Versions	
Status:	INACTIVE
Deliveries Enabled:	Tag is available, but not actively receiving data
Impressions:	0
Clicks:	0
Payloads Scheduled:	0
Payloads Delivered:	0
ID:	62

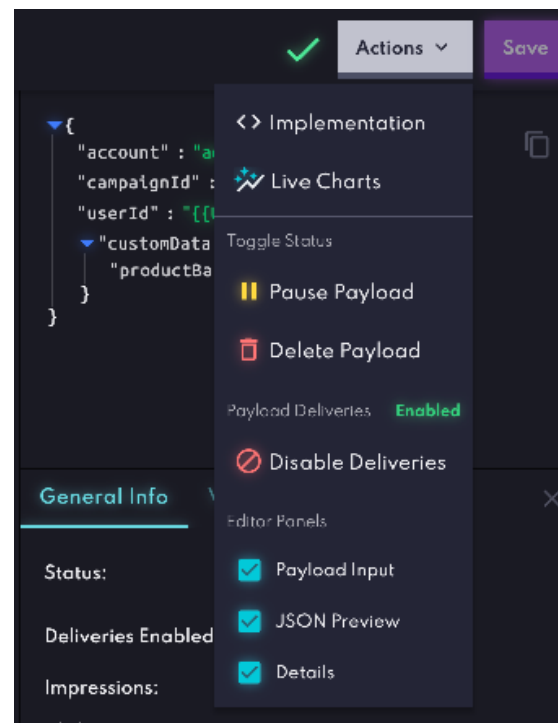
4.2 MAKE PAYLOAD ACTIONS MORE ACCESSIBLE

Participants had trouble finding important components to manage their Payloads shortly following Payload creation. For example, when instructed to find the Implementation Code, many participants expected it to be exposed on the initial post-creation screen rather than inside of the 'Actions' menu. One participant said that it was difficult to find it, because "there are other things on the screen that look like tags." Some expressed that the Implementation Code and Live Charts weren't really "actions" at all, but rather areas of additional information.

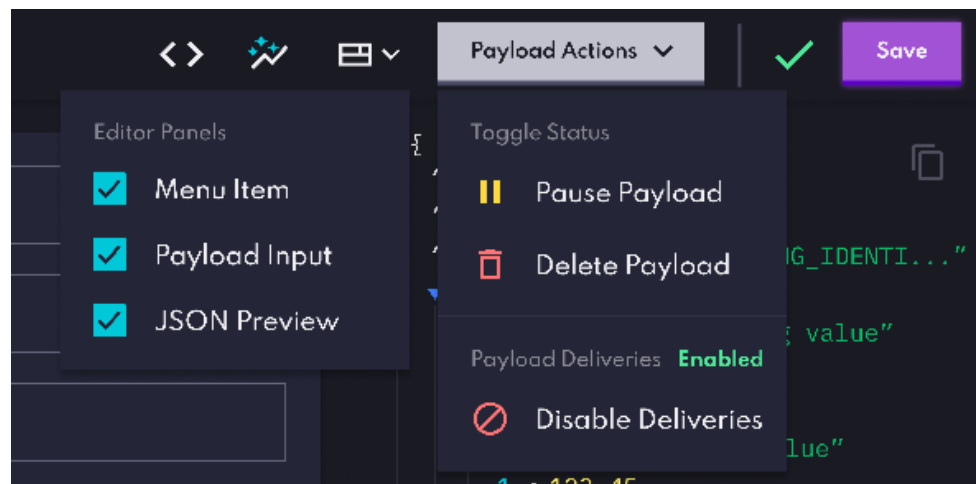
To make the post-creation screen more intuitive, we've done the following:

1. We've taken Implementation Code, Live Charts, and Editor Panels out of the original Actions menu and placed them directly on the header to increase visibility.
2. We renamed the menu to "Payload Actions" for greater clarity. Only pausing, deleting, and disabling deliveries are options within that menu, which are true actions.

BEFORE



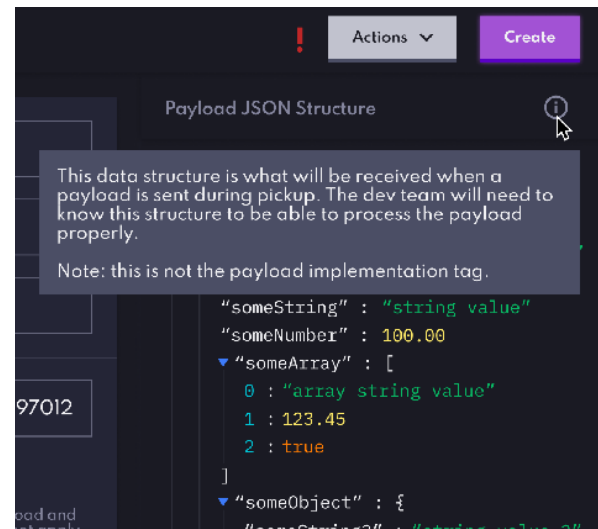
AFTER



4.3

STRENGTHEN TERMINOLOGY TO MORE CLEARLY DESCRIBE PAGE ELEMENTS, LIKE THE JSON PANEL

Users expressed confusion about the purpose of some page elements, especially during Advanced Creation setup or when viewing the post-creation screen. For example, the JSON preview is a technical piece that can overwhelm some users, but it is not labeled and its purpose is not described anywhere. Clearly labeling the JSON section with a tool tip may increase overall understanding and better guide the user toward their desired information.





ABOUT ADADAPTED

AdAdapted is an advertising technology solution that connects CPG brands to high-intent shoppers during valuable pre-shop planning moments. The company offers several solutions to drive in-store and online sales leveraging digital shopping lists, display, eCommerce, video, keyword and other touch points for CPG brands, agencies and retailers. Media can be run through managed service, self-service, and SaaS platforms.

With more than 110 million U.S. shoppers using mobile devices for their grocery lists, AdAdapted's unique adtech platform integrates with popular planning apps (think recipes,

ADADAPTED TURNS
PRE-SHOP INTENT INTO
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OF BRANDED PRODUCTS

wellness, lists, and budgeting) to reach consumers with shoppable ads when they are most receptive to a brand's message. We turn pre-shop intent into awareness and action; moving shoppers down the funnel while fueling in-store and online purchases with a single click.

AdAdapted: Proven digital advertising built for CPG brands.



UX/UI AT ADADAPTED

The User-Experience/User-Interface Design team at AdAdapted works deliberately across the company's core products to optimize their performance and usability. These products include internal tools like our Managed Service Platform (MSP) as well as client-facing tools like our self-service platform, AdAdapted Direct, and our Payload-as-a-Service platform, AdAdapted Payloads. The team works on various other projects as part of the Engineering and Research & Development teams.

UX/UI involves meticulously studying and understanding our users so that we can execute user-centered design

THE UX/UI TEAM AT ADADAPTED WORKS ACROSS ALL PRODUCTS TO DESIGN INTERFACES THAT ARE BEAUTIFUL, EVIDENCE-BASED, AND USER-CENTERED.

strategies. Through research methods like user interviews and usability testing, the team can gather direct feedback and translate that data into evidence-based design decisions. The team seeks to deliver improvements that consistently help AdAdapted to generate greater margins and boost customer satisfaction.

